

EVALUATION OF NEW AND ESTABLISHED PROGRAMS

A. Roles and Responsibilities Regarding Program Evaluation. To support a culture of continuous improvement at Loudoun County Public Schools (LCPS), program evaluation shall be a collaborative effort between program staff, Division of Research, Assessment, and School Improvement staff, Division leadership, and other key stakeholders.

1. Program staff are responsible for identifying the need for the program, designing key strategies for the target population, implementing activities as intended, and engaging in the evaluation process.

2. Division of Research, Assessment, and School Improvement (Office of Research) staff are responsible for providing technical assistance and guidance with conducting a program evaluation. The Office of Research will provide support with clarifying the roles of the evaluation team, developing the draft Program Evaluation Schedule, providing oversight of the feasibility and rigor of the program evaluations, leading peer reviews of the results, and organizing the overall program evaluations. Office of Research staff will also serve as technical advisors to program staff during the evaluation process.

3. The program sponsor is responsible for ensuring that the program staff are adhering to the schedule and actively participating in the program evaluation process.

4. Division leadership is primarily accountable for making decisions regarding which programs are created, retained, and terminated, and for providing transparency by presenting program evaluation findings to the School Board.

5. Committees are involved in providing feedback on the development of the Program Evaluation Schedule and reviewing program evaluation findings and recommendations. Committees include both the School Board committees and those defined in Policy 2310.

6. Program participants are the individuals for whom the program provides benefits. Participant data that informs the program evaluation will be collected through mixed methods of quantitative and qualitative measures such as surveys, focus groups, observations, and assessments.

7. School Board members will collaborate with the Superintendent or designee about the Program Evaluation Schedule and the need for creating, modifying, expanding, or terminating programs.

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B. Program Implementation Phases. For the purposes of evaluation, new programs are implemented in three phases.

1. Installation. The installation phase starts during the first year of program implementation. This phase also includes the early planning and development of the program such as the recruitment of program participants. The focus of this phase is to evaluate implementation factors, such as the selection of program participants, initial program participant participation, the progress made toward meeting the program's goals and objectives (both activities and initial outcomes), the satisfaction of stakeholders, and cost.

2. Integration. The integration phase occurs after the program has served program participants for one implementation cycle. This phase includes making any necessary changes to the program design based on the data collected during the installation phase. The focus of this phase is to continue collecting implementation and outcome data in support of the program's goals and objectives.

3. Established. A program enters the established phase when it has been fully implemented as designed and is being administered to all eligible program participants. The focus of this phase is to collect short- and mid-term outcome data to determine program effectiveness.

C. Planning, Implementing, and Reporting Program Evaluations. Program evaluations will be conducted through the following six steps which have been adapted from the steps in the Centers for Disease Control's [Framework for Program Evaluation](#) (1999). The steps below incorporate the principles of the CDC model in the application of the process in a school district environment. A schedule for each step will be developed to ensure that tasks are completed on a timeline consistent with the reporting deadlines.

1. Form the Evaluation Team(s). The Superintendent, or designee, will engage key stakeholders throughout the evaluation process. The first step will be to solicit feedback annually from School Board committees, Advisory Committees, as defined in Policy 2310, and other stakeholder groups. Office of Research staff will then collaborate with internal program stakeholders to determine:

- a. Who should be involved in the evaluation,
- b. The type of evaluation (e.g., first-year implementation, comprehensive, comprehensive), and

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c. The evaluation timeline.

2. Develop the Logic Model. Program staff, in collaboration with Office of Research staff, will gather information on the program to deepen their understanding of its underlying theory of action, such as the goals, needs of the target participants, resources (e.g., for operations and funding), activities, and anticipated outcomes.

3. Create the Evaluation Design and Schedule. Based on the logic model, program staff, in collaboration with Office of Research staff, will generate a mixed-methods design for the program evaluation, to include the research questions, data collection methods, and target evidence to inform the findings. Ethical considerations will be incorporated into the design process, and Office of Research staff will remain conscious of its fiscal feasibility. After the design is complete, a schedule of deliverables will be developed to monitor progress.

4. Develop Tools to Collect and Analyze Data. This step involves carrying out the evaluation, as designed, by developing instruments as needed to collect relevant qualitative and quantitative data. Data sources may include gathering information from stakeholders through surveys, program financial information, fidelity of implementation measures, and short- and medium-term outcomes. The data will then be analyzed through appropriate coding and statistical analysis software to determine the preliminary findings.

5. Develop the Evaluation Report with Recommendations. Based on the findings from the data analysis, the Office of Research will share the program's strengths and opportunities for improvement. Program staff will review the findings and make recommendations for the program. Recommendations will be proposed to the Superintendent or designee and School Board to: (a) continue the program without modification(s); (b) continue the program with modification(s); (c) expand the program; or (d) discontinue/phase out the program.

6. Disseminate the Findings. The final stage of the evaluation process seeks to ensure that the knowledge gained from the evaluation is communicated to key stakeholders. Additionally, the evaluation report should be used to improve the implementation of the program. Program staff will collaborate with content experts to review and incorporate any evaluation report recommendations. Other departments may be involved in disseminating the findings to ensure that the evaluation results are effectively communicated, organizational learning occurs, and the recommended improvement strategies are implemented.

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D. Requirements for New Programs. Prior to the implementation of any newly approved program as defined by Policy 3310, the program sponsor shall submit an evaluation plan to the Office of Research. The evaluation plan shall contain data supporting the need for the program, an explanation of how the program is aligned with the current or most recent strategic plan, and a budget. New programs will be evaluated during the installation and integration phases of operation.

E. Scheduling Program Evaluations. Program evaluation will be conducted based on a three-year Program Evaluation Schedule. The Superintendent or designee will collaborate with the Office of Research to review established programs to determine the measured need of each program for evaluation as determined by the priority areas defined in Policy 3310.

Each program will receive a prioritization measure for presentation to the School Board. Placement on the schedule will be determined by the overall level of prioritization. Development of the Program Evaluation Schedule will require flexibility to accommodate both the evaluation requirements for new programs as outlined under Part D above and any unscheduled evaluations for established programs.

The three-year Program Evaluation Schedule will be reviewed annually. Programs may be added, removed, or adjusted within the schedule for the following school year. The Superintendent will consider feedback from the stakeholder groups by June 15 and approve the evaluation schedule by September 30 of each respective year.

F. Requirements for Established Programs. Established programs on the Program Evaluation Schedule will participate in a Comprehensive Evaluation beginning with a program assessment to determine if the program's goals, objectives, activities, and outcomes are aligned, plausible, well-defined, and measurable. If the program lacks any of these components, the Office of Research will assist program staff with developing an evaluation plan. To document progress with the plan, one or more Evaluation Readiness Reports will be presented to the Superintendent, or designee and shared with the School Board. Programs that have the necessary evaluation components will proceed with a Comprehensive Evaluation, which will include measures of both implementation and outcomes.

All other established programs will be placed on a five-year evaluation cycle during which program staff will conduct a self-study by the beginning of the third year of the cycle. The purpose of the self-study is to provide the program sponsor and other key stakeholders with feedback about program implementation and outcomes. This feedback can be used to make any necessary changes if the program is selected for a Comprehensive Evaluation in the future. Programs with an existing evaluation plan will

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use the implementation and outcome metrics in that plan. Programs that do not have an evaluation plan will conduct the self-study by taking the following steps:

1. Conduct a program assessment as defined in Policy 3310;
2. Review the programs goals;
3. Determine how the program is being implemented to achieve program goals;
4. Identify and collect program implementation data;
5. Determine the program outcomes based on program goals;
6. Identify and collect program outcome data;
7. Analyze and summarize implementation and outcome data; and
8. Make any necessary program modifications based on self-study results.

The Office of Research will provide training and technical assistance to program staff who are involved in conducting a self-study.

G. Reporting. Reporting for the Program Evaluation Schedule will occur at a minimum in alignment with the Strategic Plan's Fall and Spring evaluation timeframes. Specialized Programs and Centers under Policy 5115 will be subject to an additional May reporting schedule.

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Cross Refs: [Policy 2310](#), Committees of the School Board; [Policy 3310](#) , Evaluation of New and Established Programs; [Policy 5115](#) , Special Programs and Academies